

UNDERSTANDING

Learned Helplessness

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UNDERSTANDING **Learned Helplessness**

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Introduction

There are a lot of people who fall into habitual behaviours that hurt others. Most of the time the perpetrators are not aware of it. Sadly, however, it's sometimes deliberate.

One of these behaviours is creating Learned Helplessness in someone which can lead to a feeling of hopelessness or even clinical depression.

Back in the 1960s Professor Martin Seligman and colleagues ran experiments using dogs. They set up a situation whereby dogs failed to escape shock which was induced by uncontrollable events. It is documented that 'nothing the dogs did mattered'.

They concluded that the dogs accepted the feeling of being powerless, and the absence of control over aversive situations led to Learned Helplessness.

It turns out that Seligman's original theory got it 'backwards', so it's not all doom and gloom!

Therefore, the last chapter in this ebook will further explain how Seligman's initial findings have been developed and expanded upon in recent years and offer the basis of hope and optimism.



Learned Helplessness in Childhood

Imagine a child who wakes up in the morning and the first words a parent speaks to the child is criticism or nagging or a general intolerance and irritation.

The child is drowsy, with sugar levels low from a night of sleep, and they are already wrong. They try hard in their little way, but they can't please the parent.

It's as if the parent doesn't like them.

They go to school and come home to be met with the same angry face, the same nagging. They ask for food (school lunch was hours ago and not very satisfying), but the parent wants them to eat something other than what they asked for. More nagging.

They try to do something to please the parent. This gets a smile. So

they do more of it, desperate to expand upon this positive moment. But the parent gets disgruntled and shouts at the child.

Whatever the child does is not good enough in the eyes of the parent.

The nagging is constant so the child switches off, thus getting into more trouble for 'not listening'.

Feeling worn down, they start to display new behaviours.

They become loud to drown out the negativity.

Or they become withdrawn and quiet to keep out of trouble.

They may stammer or develop a tic.

They may get into trouble at school.

And strangely, they may try very hard to show love for the parent by wanting to sit next to them, by playing at something the parent likes, by writing lovely stories about them in school. It is their way to seek the approval they long for.

But still they can't do anything right.

This is learned helplessness.

Are you this parent or teacher or caregiver? Do you know someone who is? They may not realise what they are doing.

Being aware of their behaviour is a massive step towards stopping such cruelty.



Learned Helplessness in Adult Partnerships

Let's talk about Sam and Ashley. They have been together for some time now.

Sam used to be outgoing, fun and ambitious, but as time has moved on, Sam is no longer motivated to do very much, half-heartedly trying things and giving up quickly thus exacerbating low self-esteem. In fact, Sam feels a failure at most things.

Ashley on the other hand, tries to demonstrate power. You will often hear Ashley being sarcastic about Sam, belittling and blaming Sam for anything and everything.

If you are concerned for the Sams of the world, you may decide to have a quiet word to see if they are OK. Sam is likely to protect Ashley and

make excuses for them, for what is quite clearly emotional abuse.

Sam may also be frightened that if Ashley is confronted it could make things worse.

You see, Sam loves Ashley but feels helpless with little control. In fact, Ashley is so good at putting Sam down that Sam often feels guilty for no reason other than that's how Ashley has made them feel.

Constant belittling and sarcasm are not funny, it does not make the perpetrator look big and powerful, in fact it makes them look small and weak. As for the recipient, it's a very cruel way to live with such corrosive behaviour.

Sam is experiencing Learned Helplessness which can lead to depression and other issues.

This is not a healthy relationship. This is not acceptable.

Are you a Sam or an Ashley? Do you know a Sam or an Ashley?



Learned Helplessness in Working Relationships

"Great idea. How about writing me a report and I'll look into it"

... Report created and delivered but it was never actioned nor talked about again.

"Great idea, but you're too late, Haani has thought of something better"

... A response this person has heard far too often.

"Why can't you just do as I ask? You never seem to be on the same wavelength."

... Another put down.

These are examples of Learned Helplessness in the workplace.

When you are sick of feeling disempowered by comments and lack of interest or actions for your contributions to the team and you can't seem to do anything right, it's ghastly. Motivation flies out of the window. Self-esteem and self-worth deteriorate.

If you are an employee who experiences this sort of thing on a regular basis, there are things you can do to get out of the loop, which we will cover in the last chapter.

If you are a manager or colleague that uses throw away comments like this, think again. No one gains from putting others down and you only look inadequate.



Learned Helplessness in Our Older Years

Do you have an elderly parent or parents?

As a grown-up child we tend to take over, don't we. We have come to a point in our lives when making decisions is second nature and we think we know best.

Of course, sometimes we have doubts but there is so much to do that we just plough ahead.

And sometimes we make decisions for our elderly parents.

To be honest, it doesn't even have to be adult children. I can remember being in a shop when one of my children (around 10 years old), took my purse away from me because, in their opinion, I was taking a bit too

long, so they paid for me.

It starts early. Naturally I made it clear I didn't want this to happen again (whilst laughing inside), but you can see how these things creep up on us.

So your parent(s) is/are living independently, but they need help with the garden or the cleaning or more. Or perhaps they are in a residential home, where the staff do everything for your loved one.

That all seems good doesn't it? But in everyone's attempt to be loving and helpful, we can actually take away any semblance of control they have.

They begin to feel useless. They may try to get up and clear the table, but someone says "no, I'll do that". They may wish to dress for bed themselves, but someone says "you are taking too long, let me do that". They may try to choose what to wear in the morning, but someone says "oh come on, I have others to help" or "hurry up, I've got to get to work".

Whatever they try to do, they are stopped or they are criticised.

This is learned helplessness.

The person will feel they are useless and may become anxious and/or depressed.

This is not helpful, it's actually unkind or even cruel. In our attempt to 'do our best for them', our lack of thinking clearly is hurting them.



From Learned Helplessness to Optimistic Hopefulness

Are you a child or adult; in an adult relationship; an employee or a manager; a carer or cared for?

Unless you live on a remote island with no other human beings in sight, you need to read this.

Originally researched by Professor Martin Seligman in the 1960s, it was thought that Learned Helplessness was an inability to escape induced uncontrollable events to the point where the person feels that whatever they did didn't matter.

This can lead to anxiety disorder and depression, so is extremely important to understand.

More recently however, Seligman and colleagues have found that there is nothing in the brain that is turned on by lack of control in this context. Rather it is something that turns off when there is control.

According to this research, the brain seems to detect control (in this context) not the lack of control (please note that the brain can detect lack of control in other scenarios).

Seligman suggests that the ventromedial prefrontal cortex and dorsal raphe nucleus areas of the brain are a top-down circuitry which he calls a 'hope' circuit.

This means that we have a natural defence against helplessness, as our brains expect the bad things that are happening to be only temporary.

This does NOT excuse the perpetrators to continue to behave in a way that makes people feel useless. If this is you, please think and stop such controlling behaviour.

However, it does enable us to see a light at the end of the tunnel.



Simple Tips to Help the Person Who is Feeling Helpless

1. Set achievable goals for yourself

Through achievement we can increase our self-worth and self-esteem. We begin to realise how well we are doing.

2. Speak to a mental health professional

Discussing possible traumas, negative emotions and negative thoughts can help you recognise underlying problems and do something about them.

3. Talk to someone you trust who cares for you

Chatting things through with a kind compassionate friend or family member will help you feel supported. Their encouragement can go a long way.

4. Is your behaviour becoming a self-fulfilling prophecy?

Ask yourself if you are acting helpless, which may contribute to others treating you as helpless. If this is the case, stand tall, take deep breaths and tweak your behaviour to break out of the loop.

5. Practice thinking of the good things

Try to turn your mind to the things that are working well, even if it's the sunshine or good food. Start small and build up to noticing what's going right. It will change your brain chemistry for the better.

Tips to Help a Child

Clearly these tips are for adults or older children. What can a young child do?

A young child will find it hard to help themselves, because they are unlikely to understand what is going on. So, it is important for other adults in the child's life to be aware and notice when they are struggling with school work or their behaviour has changed.

1. Encourage and praise effort

Trying hard is success in itself. Work on their growth mindset (Dr Carol Dweck is an authority on this, look her up).

2. Discuss their strengths with them

Get them to use their strengths, so that they enjoy and achieve success more readily.

3. Think of ways they can succeed

If they are fun, all the better.

4. Discuss looking forward to events that they will enjoy

Optimism is a key to getting over the feeling of powerlessness.

Conclusion

If you are a person or you know a person who is creating learned helplessness, please be aware of what you are saying and how you are behaving. Are you constantly in a negative mindset of your own? Are you always nagging and grumbling about something? Do you see the worst in things?

No one likes a grumpy person and you may even be making situations far more difficult than they need to be. If you are unsure, ask for feedback from people. Show your strength by quietly changing your behaviour for the better.

In the meantime, this is a message for us all. Hope is powerful, but if you can remove yourself away from toxic people, please do so.

I hope you found this ebook useful.

I always welcome comments and ideas. So do get in touch.

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Further reading

- Dweck Carol, Dunne B (2019) *Mindset – Changing the Way You Think to Fulfil Your Potential*. Hatchette Audio UK
- Maier SF & Seligman ME (2016) Learned Helplessness at Fifty: Insights from Neuroscience. *Psychol Rev* 123 (4) 349-367
- Seligman ME (1972) “Learned Helplessness” *Annual Review of Medicine* 23 (1) 407-412

About the Author

Lynda Shaw - Neuroscientist, business psychologist and change specialist

Lynda is an experienced entrepreneur having owned 3 businesses.



She holds a doctorate in cognitive neuroscience, specialising in unconscious processing of emotion and behavioural change.

She works with senior leaders and their teams who want to better understand the science of change and development and harness this power through heightened awareness of how their brain works, limiting beliefs and how to take charge of one's behavior for the better in this fast-changing world.

A regular presenter, Lynda is a cognitive neuroscientist, registered chartered psychologist, an Associate Fellow of the British Psychological Society, a Fellow of the Royal Society of Medicine, a Fellow and President Elect of the Professional Speakers Association, holder of the prestigious Professional Speaker Association award for Excellence, she is an enthusiastic and engaging speaker. A Forbes contributor as well as an entrepreneur and author of adult and children's books.

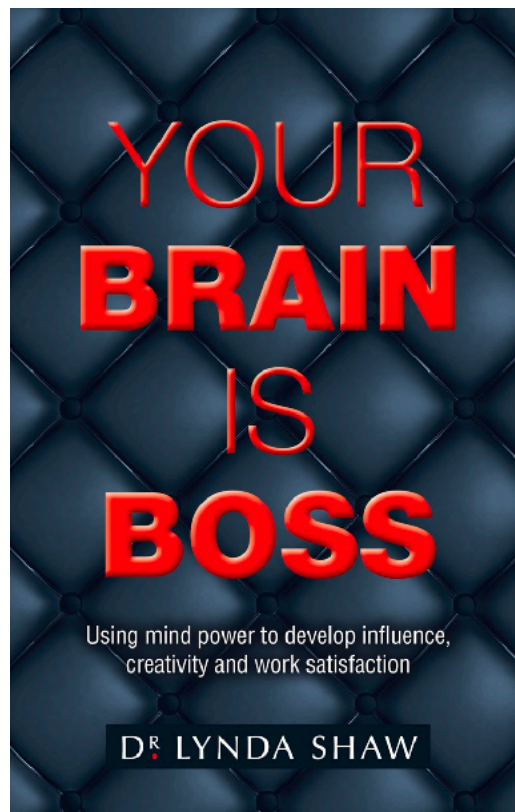
She is founder of the Neuroscience Professional Development Programme designed to help professional people use applied neuroscience in their work. Lynda's work is always informative, fun and extremely practical.

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Get the book here:

<https://www.amazon.co.uk/Your-Brain-Boss-creativity-satisfaction/dp/1912300044>

"Thank you so much for your very rewarding, compelling, interesting, warm and funny presentation last night. It was a real success."

- Conference Organiser, Lloyds Bank

"I have just completed the Neuroscience Professional Development online programme created and hosted by Lynda. What a superb experience. Lynda is naturally extremely knowledgeable but works to help simplify some of the concepts to ensure relevance for the work done by each person attending. The combination of self-led learning through video and reading content, together with group Q&A sessions has been perfect - and a lot of fun. If anyone is even thinking about working with Lynda, do it! I couldn't recommend her enough - thank you so much Lynda!"

- Jackie Handy, Embedding Inclusion In Business

